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Urgent action needed to restore degraded Marlborough Sounds

17 December 2024

The Environmental Defence Society today released its oceans case study on the Marlborough Sounds. The case study is part of EDS's broader oceans reform project which is developing concrete recommendations for oceans management reform.

"The Marlborough Sounds is an iconic and unique marine area with an intricate web of marine inlets and islands that contain a wide diversity of marine life comprising one tenth of the nation's entire coastline," said EDS Policy Director and case study author Raewyn Peart.

"The Sounds has long attracted people, and it has a rich history of Māori and European occupation. It is a popular place for fishing and tourism, and it supports more than half the country's aquaculture industry.

"However, the Sounds is now suffering severe and ongoing degradation. Fish stocks are depleted, marine farm productivity is reduced, and important marine habitats and biodiversity have been lost.

"Key stressors are high levels of sedimentation, damage to seabed habitats from bottom trawling and dredging, over-harvesting of fish stocks and climate change. Any one of these stressors is damaging on its own but, cumulatively, they have had a devastating impact on the Sounds marine ecosystems.

"There are many good things happening in the Sounds, supported by iwi, including mussel and kelp restoration efforts. However, they are small scale and need greater support. They will also only succeed if other stressors on the marine system, such as sediment and over-harvesting, are addressed as well.

"The case study identifies a range of initiatives that could support restoration of the Marlborough Sounds including:

- Preparing a regular 'State of Our Sounds' report
- Developing a regional Marlborough Sounds Fisheries Plan
- Developing a Marlborough Sounds Marine Restoration Plan
- Establishing a Marlborough Sounds Marine Restoration Fund
- Establishing a Marlborough Sounds Guardians body and/or legal personhood for the Marlborough Sounds

"We plan to present the findings of the case study to the community, in the New Year, as part of a community workshop.

"Urgent action is needed to bring the Marlborough Sounds back to health," concluded Ms Peart.

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Access the Marlborough Sounds Case Study Report [here](#)

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